



Fast Fashion

Who pays for a bargain?

Clothes have never been cheaper. The question is who covers the difference.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.



Cheap clothes are quickly worn out and thrown onto growing textile waste piles.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Think of the last item of clothing you bought. Besides you, who might have paid for it?
2. Is buying less always more ethical than buying better? When might it not be?

A T-shirt that costs less than a sandwich ought to raise a question, yet most of us never ask it. Fast fashion has made new clothes so cheap and plentiful that buying them feels almost weightless: a few taps, a parcel at the door, a garment worn twice and forgotten. **On the face of it**, this is a success story. Clothing that was once a considered purchase is now within almost everyone's reach. The trouble is that the price on the tag is rarely the whole price.

Low prices **come at a cost**; it is simply paid elsewhere. Brands compete by producing faster and cheaper, pressing suppliers to cut wages and safety checks in what critics call **a race to the bottom**. When a factory building collapsed in Bangladesh, killing more than a thousand garment workers, the world briefly paid attention. The industry is also a heavy user of water, and synthetic fabrics shed tiny plastic fibers with every wash.

Shoppers who want to do better face a thicket of imperfect choices. Donating old clothes may **salve your conscience**, but much of what charities receive is shipped abroad in bales, where it can swamp local markets and end up in landfills anyway. "Eco" collections promise greener cotton while the overall volume of production keeps rising.

Even boycotts can **backfire**. Garment work is often one of the few formal jobs open to women in poorer countries, and a collapse in orders would hurt the very workers campaigners mean to help. Some argue the answer is regulation, making brands answerable for conditions throughout their supply chains. Others say the only real solution is to buy far less, though few seem willing to be the first to stop.

Is a cheap shirt a bargain if someone else pays for it?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the expressions (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. come at a cost ____ | A. to ease feelings of guilt |
| 2. a race to the bottom ____ | B. at first glance |
| 3. salve your conscience ____ | C. to have the opposite effect |
| 4. on the face of it ____ | D. to involve a hidden loss |
| 5. backfire ____ | E. a contest to cut standards |

TRUE OR FALSE

Judge what the article states *or implies*. Circle T or F.

- | | |
|--|-------------------|
| 1. The writer implies cheapness hides costs. | T F |
| 2. Donated clothes mostly stay local. | T F |
| 3. The writer urges a consumer boycott. | T F |
| 4. Eco lines may not cut total output. | T F |
| 5. The writer doubts shoppers will cut back. | T F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 Would you pay double for a shirt if you knew the worker earned a fair wage?
- 2 Is fast fashion driven more by brands, or by what shoppers demand?
- 3 Why might a well-meant boycott hurt the people it aims to help?
- 4 Should brands be legally responsible for every factory in their supply chain?
- 5 Can a culture built on cheap abundance ever choose to want less?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

GOOD INTENTIONS, SIDE EFFECTS

Each action below is meant to help. Any of them could also backfire.

Predict one side effect for each action. Then circle whether it does more good (+), more harm (–), or is unclear (?).

ACTION	MEANT TO	COULD ALSO...	OVERALL
Boycott cheap brands	protect garment workers	_____	+ – ?
Donate your old clothes	keep clothes out of landfill	_____	+ – ?
Buy only “eco” lines	cut environmental harm	_____	+ – ?
Tax every new garment	slow down overbuying	_____	+ – ?
Ban used-clothing exports	stop dumping on poorer countries	_____	+ – ?
Simply buy far less	shrink production overall	_____	+ – ?

YOUR VERDICT Most effective action: _____ The side effect you would accept for it: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Which side effect is most serious, and who would pay for it?
 - 2 Compare with another pair. Challenge one action they rated differently.
 - 3 Is an action worth taking if its benefits are certain but its harms are not?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with an expression from the box.
Change the form if you need to.

backfire **salve your conscience**
on the face of it **a race to the bottom**
come at a cost

- 1 Cheap flights _____ we rarely see.
- 2 Tax cuts fueled _____ between states.
- 3 She recycles mainly to _____.
- 4 _____, the deal looked generous.
- 5 The ban _____ and raised prices.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

“Shoppers cannot shop their way out of fast fashion.” To what extent do you agree?

Write 200–250 words. Address the strongest opposing view before you answer it.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • PROPOSE • DEFEND

In small groups, build one position and hold it under pressure.

- ROLE** You run a clothing brand under pressure to clean up its supply chain.
- PROPOSE** Commit to ONE change. Say what it will cost, and who will notice the difference.
- DEFEND** Present in two minutes. Campaigners then argue it does not go far enough. Answer them without abandoning your plan.